

SAILING SOLO
BSP chief Mayawati has decided to contest all upcoming elections without alliances

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UTTAR PRADESH

MAYAWATI TO FIGHT ALONE

her 67th birthday, Mayawati ruled out any alliance with other parties for the assembly polls as well as for the general election. She announced that in the assembly elections to Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan this year and in the Lok Sabha polls, the BSP will eschew tie-ups and go it alone.

Akhilesh, on his part, transmitted a more amenable aspect to the rest of the field. The former UP chief minister, along with other opposition leaders, attended Telangana chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao's rally in Khammam on January 18, thus raising hopes for the revival of that elusive entity in Indian politics—a 'third front'. The meeting was significant as it was the first show of unity and intent after the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) decided to go national by renaming itself Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS). Akhilesh hinted that he was open to joining a third front for the 2024 showdown. With discussion centering on an effective national opposition against the BJP, politicians and analysts are left to read the tea leaves. Some observers believe that in UP at least, the BJP, SP, BSP and Congress would have a four-cornered fight, with the ruling party having the natural advantage.

In her recent statement, Mayawati said, "In electoral alliances forged in Uttar Pradesh and other states, barring Punjab, votes (of the allies) were not transferred to us, due to which the BSP suffered losses. Hence, our party has decided to contest the assembly and Lok Sabha polls on its own." Key BSP leaders claim this is part of the party's strategy for a revival. The BSP high command apparently wants to give a message to the rank and file—somewhat demoralised after the party won just one seat in the 2022 assembly polls—that it is still capable of fighting alone. A senior BSP functionary tells INDIA TODAY, "We are now focusing on Dalit-Muslim-MBC (Most Backward Class) unity. To focus on this, responsibility has been given to leaders, including Imran Masood (the ex-MLA from western UP who joined the party recently) and the new BSP state chief Vishwanath Pal. We want to recreate and boost our local leadership before the 2024 polls. So, Behenji announced that the party will contest all seats alone." Elaborating further on the party's revival plans, Pal says: "Our focus is to regain our strength in every district. We are focusing on organisation," he says. On the question of a dent in BSP's Dalit votebank, he adds, "The Dalit has not gone anywhere. The Muslim was misled; backwards were also misled. Now everyone is realising BSP is a better option."

Mayawati, who focused on the Brahmin community before the 2022 assembly polls, promising them 'security', now seems to be trying to woo Muslims. Soon after the assembly poll results—where the BSP got only 12.8 per cent of the vote share—she had said that the "wrong decision" of the

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